initiatives of 2008 and Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to Lahore in 2015—have been stymied by the Pakistani military establishment, which engineered or approved the Kargil incursion in 1999, the Mumbai terrorist attacks in 2008 and the Pathankot attack of 2015.

Continued Indian engagement with Pakistan, even if at a low level, is sometimes necessary to maintain direct channels of communication and prevent third-party mediation, which India believes could tilt outcomes in Pakistan's favour. The growing power disparity in India's favour helps it in the long run, whereas Pakistan has often sought to internationalize bilateral differences and use external mediators to pressure India into making greater concessions. Bilateral engagement will remain one way of forestalling that possibility and is a major reason for why every Indian prime minister since 1998 has made a concerted effort to engage with Pakistan. Continued outreach to civilian political leaders, the business community, and elements of Pakistan's civil society may still have some value for India, even if it is obvious that the Pakistan Army retains ultimate veto power on relations with India.

The reality is that India's efforts at compelling Pakistan using sticks and carrots will be a long-term effort—and will depend on a multitude of factors. The growing Pakistani dependence on China (as a consequence of the China Pakistan Economic Corridor or CPEC), a more contested Afghanistan, and a Pakistan in domestic political disarray make the prospects of compelling its Army more remote. By contrast, any durable solution from India's standpoint would benefit from a capable leader on the Pakistani side, the Pakistan Army's acquiescence, and Pakistan's relative international isolation. These are the conditions that would be more conducive to Pakistan abandoning its long-standing policy of supporting terrorism against India and Indian interests.

One reason for continuing pessimism remains the strategic culture of the Pakistan Army. The army sees its role as protecting the country's 'ideological frontiers' rather than its security. As C. Christine Fair concludes upon assessing the Pakistan Army's own writings, 'Pakistan will suffer any number of military defeats in its efforts to [undermine India's position], but